

Preventative medicine

Find out how to limit the need for troubleshooting your computer by looking after it. Here, we suggest some ways to avoid PC problems from the start

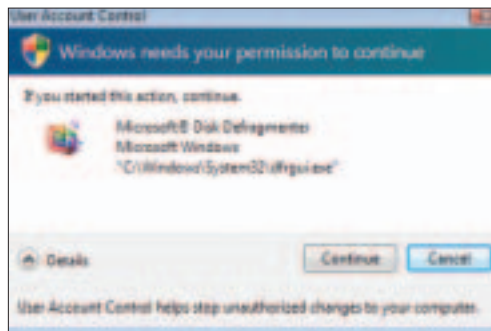
When it comes to computers in general, and Windows in particular, prevention is usually far better than cure. Rather than waiting for something to go wrong and then panicking to find a solution, it is advisable to have a number of safeguards in place to either help avoid problems in the first place, or at least to make it easier to get everything back to normal.

A combination of good practices and preferable computing habits can help to avoid disaster down the line, and Vista includes more features as standard to help avoid problems than any previous version of Windows.

Over the next few pages, we'll be looking at how many computer crises can be averted altogether with a little know-how.

Avoidance is best

Microsoft understands the old prevention/cure tenet better than most, which is why it has crammed Windows Vista full of new features designed to prevent many problems from ever occurring. One such precautionary element is Vista's User Account Control (UAC), which is basically a warning message that freezes your screen. In general day-to-day use, it is something you may encounter only rarely.



The User Account Control displays a message if a dangerous change is about to be made to your PC

It's designed to spring into action only when potentially dangerous changes are about to be made to your computer; for example, when certain system settings are accessed.

Usually, User Account Control will not prevent an action from being

performed altogether, but you'll need to click 'Continue' to get past it or supply an administrative username and password if you're logged on with a Standard user account (see below).

While User Account Control can be turned off, it is far from advisable. The very act of disabling the feature can sometimes have detrimental effects in its own right but, more importantly, switching UAC off could potentially leave your system open to abuse from malicious hackers.



Ensure your security settings are up to date regularly

Password protected

User accounts are a good way of preventing many kinds of accidental and security-based problems from ever occurring. It is a good idea to assign everybody that uses the computer their own user account and password protect each one. On a basic level, this helps to avoid the potential problem of one user deleting another's files, and if users are assigned

Standard accounts, they can also be prevented from making unwanted changes to system settings. You may even want to consider using a Standard user account yourself for your day-to-day computer use, reserving your Administrator account only

for such times when you need to make use of its privileges. With a Standard user account, any action that could change key system settings or works with important system files requires the entry of an Administrator password. As some malware can change settings and files, many threats can be stopped in their tracks by not providing them with Administrator privileges.



Assign a user account to each person who uses your PC